

## HOW TO PROSPER IN TOUGH ECONOMIC TIMES

\* DENOTES POWER POINT SLIDE

\* DENOTES INSTRUCTIONS TO TECHNICIAN

**INTRO:** American affluence has led to an overall denial of the need for the Lord to bless His people in this culture. When you stop to consider the socio-economic status of Americans, we may actually be more dependent on the blessings of the Lord than we think!

The Center for American Progress recently made the following statement: *“America’s families are caught in a perfect storm. Massive amounts of debt, falling house prices, disappearing jobs, flat wages, lower wages, and skyrocketing costs for the most important consumer items are quickly emptying the pockets of middle class America and bringing many families to the edge of financial ruin.”* They released the following statistics in April of 2008: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- Jobs – Employment declined by 80,000 jobs in March 2008 – This represents the largest loss since March 2003.
- Wages – Despite inflation wages remain flat. Compared to March of 2001 the hourly wage of an individual in February 2008 was up 2.3% and the weekly wages were 1.1% higher! This is over a seven year period!
- Pensions and Health Insurance – The share of private sector workers with a pension dropped

from 50.3% in 2000 to 43.2% in 2006. In the same period the share of employees with employer-provided health coverage dropped from 64.2% to 59.7%.

- **Family Debt** – Household debt averaged a record 133.7% of disposable income in the fourth quarter of 2007! In the fourth quarter of 2007 families spent 14.3% of their disposable income to service their debt, up from 13% in the first quarter of 2001.
- **Housing Crisis** – New home sales in February 2008 were 28.9% lower than a year earlier. The median sales price of a home dropped 2.7%. The total values of homes fell by 1.8% in the fourth quarter of 2007. This is the largest drop since the third quarter of 1975! Home equity as a share of home values also fell to a record low of 47.9%. Foreclosures have hit a record high with 2% of all homes in foreclosure. The bankruptcy rate is up 85.2% from the first quarter of 2006 to the third quarter of 2007. Credit card defaults rose to 4.2% of all credit card debt by the fourth quarter of 2007, an increase of 32.6% from the first quarter of 2006!
- **Oil and Gas Prices** – The price of crude oil at the end of March 2008 which was to be delivered in the next month, was 54.2% higher than a year earlier! According to Aaron Wissner, in 2003 the average price for a gallon of gas was \$1.50 compared to \$3.47 in April 2008. He also predicts we could see \$10.00 per gallon gas in the next seven years! Does this

sound crazy? In March of 2008 the average price of gas in Europe was \$9.30 per gallon!

- People Paying More for Basics – Transportation costs 9.5% more in January 2008 than a year earlier, college tuition is up 6.2%, fuel and utilities is up by 5.6%, medical care is up 4.5%, the cost of food is up 4.6%,. Since March 2001 food prices have rose by 21.6%, fuels and utilities 36.3%, medical care 34.1%, transportation 26.1% and college tuition by 63.5%!
- National Deficit Increases - In January 2008, the Congressional Budget Office estimated that the deficit for 2008 will amount to \$219 Billion - \$56 Billion more than in 2007 – This is really frightening when you consider that this is not even taking into account the economic stimulus package or the wars in Afghanistan or Iraq!
- The Value of the Dollar is Falling – By the end of March 2008, a dollar bought 44.4% fewer euros, 34.1% fewer Canadian dollars, 39.9% fewer British pounds, and 18.2% fewer Japanese Yen than in March 2001. After inflation, the dollar has lost 22.2% of its value against its trading partner currencies between march 2001 and March 2008!

The truth about the American dream is that there are a limited number of rich people at the top of the socio-economic ladder of success and the vast majority of the population is struggling to keep their head above the proverbial financial water!

I have three reasons for preaching on the subject of stewardship today: (1) I have given my way out of poverty **(PLACE PHOTOS OF HOUSES I GREW UP IN ON THE SCREEN, LEAVE UP UNTIL I AM FINISHED WITH POINT 3)** (2) I want to see the people of CT Church get blessed. (3) I want CT Church to have the resources necessary to carry out its assignment in this city

Before I am finished today I will prove to you that this church has sufficient people and resources to accomplish the task God has called us to. What each of us must do is to step up to the plate and be faithful with the resources He has placed into our hands! When we do this, we set in motion **the blessing of the Lord** which **will bring to pass two things: (PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- **The blessing of the Lord will rest upon His people.**
- **God adequately resources His church.**

In essence, when we fix one problem, we get all our needs supplied!

You may ask why it would be necessary for the pastor of a church like Christian Temple to talk about money; especially tithing and giving. We automatically assume everyone in the church is doing their part to advance the kingdom. Let me share some information with you which you may find alarming. **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

**In general:**

- 49% of adults believe the Bible teaches that money is the root of all evil. (What it really teaches is **“The love of money is the root of all evil”** – You can love it without having it, and you can have it without loving it)
- Adults who attend protestant churches contribute an average of \$74.00 per month.
- 37% of adults who attend church regularly do not contribute any money.
- 3% of adults donate at least 10% of their income to a church or religious organization.

**(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

2007 Christian Temple stats:

TITHE:

- 94% of the people gave SOMETHING to tithe in 2007
- 49.83% of the people gave less than 1K to tithe in 2007
- 28.92% of the people gave between 1K and 5K to tithe in 2007
- 21.73% of the people gave more than 5K to tithe in 2007
- 7.85% of the people gave more than 10K to tithe in 2007
- 90.65% of total tithe dollars was contributed by 39.13% of the people in 2007

From these stats we could draw the following conclusion:

- 49.83% of the families of this church live on less than \$10,000.00 per year

- 78.75% of the families of this church live on less than \$50,000.00 per year

#### MISSIONS:

- 51.88% of the people gave something to missions in 2007
- 48.12% of the people in this church gave nothing to missions in 2007
- 27.44% of the total income of the church went to missions (\$689,596.45)

Let us look at what the Word of God has to say on this subject. **Malachi 3:10** (KJV) *"Bring all the tithes into the storehouse, That there may be food in My house, And try Me now in this," Says the LORD of hosts, "If I will not open for you the windows of heaven and pour out for you such blessing that there will not be room enough to receive it."* The word blessing comes from the Hebrew word baraka (bear-aw-kah), and means: **(PLACE ON SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

1. Source of blessing
2. Prosperity
3. Praise of God
4. A gift or present
5. A treaty of peace

A closer look at this verse would reveal our tithing produces: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

1. A constant source of blessing – Who in their right mind would refuse such a source of supply? Our faithfulness in tithing insures the

source of divine blessing will be constantly flowing in our direction.

2. **Prosperity** – Prosperity has been given a bad name by people, who want to abuse it, but the intention of our Heavenly Father is to prosper everyone who has enough integrity and character to do what is right with their finances. **Prosperity is having enough, plus a little!**
3. **Praise of God** – When we tithe faithfully, God is proud of us and even praises our works! He brags on us. The end result of God bragging on us is that we will eventually hear it from his own lips, ***"Well done good and faithful servant..."***
4. **A gift or present** – When we tithe we can get ready to receive gifts from the Lord! Not just at Christmas, on our birthday, or anniversary, but random acts of kindness when it is least expected! He will not be out given! A few days ago the Lord spoke to me to be the supplier of a \$1,500.00 need for someone in this church and before the day was over I had \$700.00 of unexpected blessing in my hand which had nothing to do with CT Church!
5. **A treaty of peace** – When we tithe, we enter into a treaty of peace! Peace in our life, home, work, church, and other relationships! Peace with God, ourselves, and His church!

We should tithe because we want to be blessed! In fact His promise is ***"I will open for you the windows of heaven and pour out for you such blessing that there will not be room enough to receive it."***

The blessing of God was apparent upon King Hezekiah when he turned to the Lord and convinced the priests and people to do what was right with their finances. [2 Chronicles 31:2-10](#) (NLT) ***“Hezekiah then organized the priests and Levites into divisions to offer the burnt offerings and peace offerings, and to worship and give thanks and praise to the LORD at the gates of the Temple. <sup>3</sup>The king also made a personal contribution of animals for the daily morning and evening burnt offerings, as well as for the weekly Sabbath festivals and monthly new moon festivals, and for the other annual festivals as required in the law of the LORD. <sup>4</sup>In addition, he required the people in Jerusalem to bring the prescribed portion of their income to the priests and Levites, so they could devote themselves fully to the law of the LORD. <sup>5</sup>The people responded immediately and generously with the first of their crops and grain, new wine, olive oil, honey, and all the produce of their fields. They brought a tithe of all they owned. <sup>6</sup>The people who had moved to Judah from Israel, and the people of Judah themselves, brought in the tithes of their cattle and sheep and a tithe of the things that had been dedicated to the LORD their God, and they piled them up in great heaps. <sup>7</sup>The first of these tithes was brought in late spring,<sup>[a]</sup> and the heaps continued to grow until early autumn.<sup>[b]</sup> <sup>8</sup>When Hezekiah and his officials came and saw these huge piles, they thanked the LORD and his people Israel! <sup>9</sup>“Where did all this come from?” Hezekiah asked the priests and Levites. <sup>10</sup>And Azariah the high priest, from the family of Zadok, replied, “Since the people***

*began bringing their gifts to the LORD's Temple, we have had enough to eat and plenty to spare, for the LORD has blessed his people."*

When we get blessed by the Lord the end result should be *"There is not room enough to receive it."*

If we tithe and give we can prosper despite tough economic times!